

Cholesterol: The Silent Risk in Filipinos

Why it matters, what to eat,
and how to **protect your heart**

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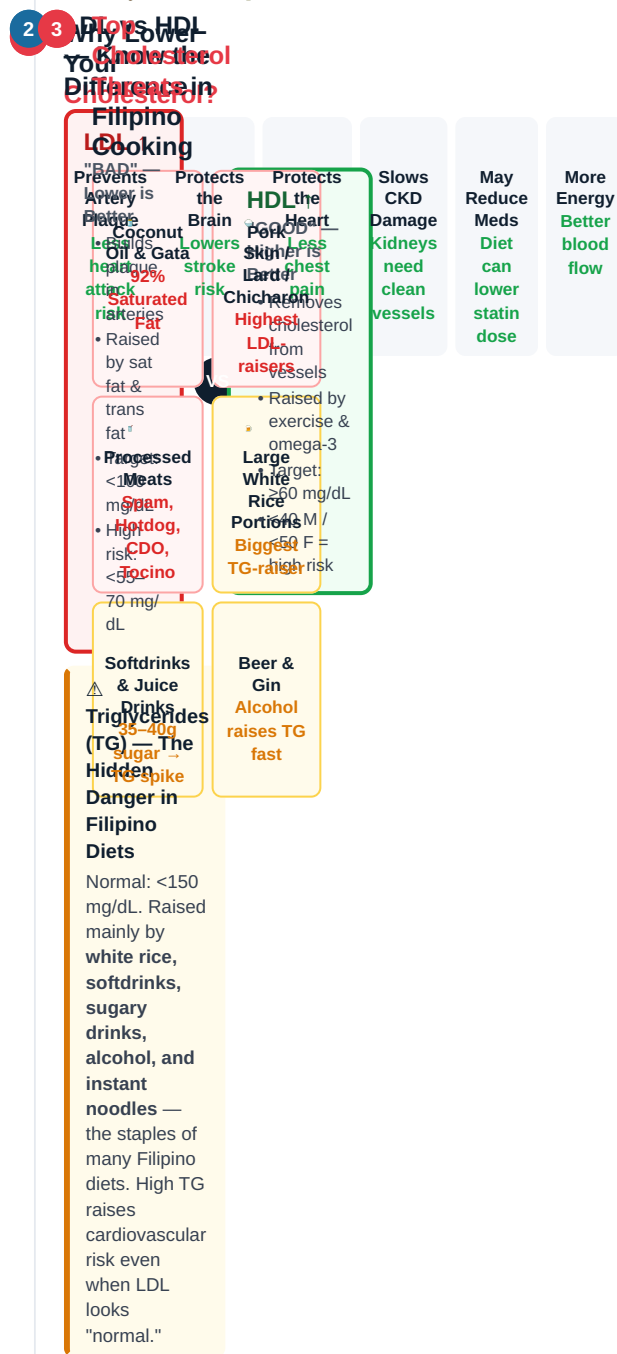
mg/dL Total Cholesterol Goal

<100

mg/dL LDL Target (most patients)

≥60

mg/dL HDL Goal (protective)



5 6 Low Different Fats Move Your Lipid Then Package Nutrition

Fat Type	LDL	HDL	TG	Common Philippine Sources
Know Your Numbers				
REMOVE	→	USE		
		INSTEAD		
Total Cholesterol	→	Canola oil		Coconut oil (VCO, Minola), lard, butter, gata, chicharon, lechon, fatty pork, full-fat cheese
<200 mg/dL	<100	or olive oil	200	
Triglycerides	→	Chicken breast or pork loin		
<150 mg/dL	<130 (kasim)			
Lechon / chicharon	→	30g pili nuts or fresh fruit	<3.5	Partially hydrogenated margarine, commercial fried food — avoid entirely
High-risk patients (CKD, diabetes, prior heart attack): LDL target may be <55–70 mg/dL — ask your doctor	→	Tinola or pinakbet (canola oil)		
Monounsaturated (MUFAs)	→	Half brown rice + smaller portions		Canola oil, olive oil, avocado, pili nuts, cashews, almonds
3-in-1 coffee / softdrinks	→	Black barako coffee / salabat / water		Sardinas (lata), galunggong, bangus, salmon — aim for 2 servings/ week
Omega-3 PUFA (EPA/DHA)	→	Sardinas (lata) or fresh tilapia		
Spam / hotdog / processed meat	→	Fresh papaya or boiled saba banana		Oatmeal, monggo, okra, kamote — 5–10 g/ day lowers LDL ~5–11 mg/dL
Leche flan / halo-halo	→			
Sugar & Refined Carbs	—			White rice (large portions), softdrinks, instant noodles, white bread — biggest TG driver in Filipino diet
Alcohol	—			Beer, gin, lambanog — even moderate use raises TG; stopping often drops TG 30–50% in weeks

HOW TO READ PAGES 2–3:

AVOID

= high cardiovascular risk

LIMIT

= occasional, small portion

GOOD

= eat freely, heart-healthy

H

High

M

Moderate

L

Low

SF

=Saturated Fat

SUG

=Sugar/Refined Carbs (TG driver)

CHOL

=Dietary Cholesterol

Food Item (Filipino Name)	Typical Serving	SF	SUG	CHOL	Rating	Key Note
A · LUTONG-BAHAY — PORK & BEEF DISHES						
Lechon baboy (whole roasted pig)	1 slice 100g	H	L	H	AVOID	Skin = pure saturated fat; organ stuffing raises dietary cholesterol further
Crispy pata (deep-fried pork knuckle)	1 piece 150g	H	L	H	AVOID	Pork skin + knuckle = very high saturated fat and dietary cholesterol
Chicharon bulaklak (pork mesentery, fried)	50 g	H	L	H	AVOID	Organ membrane deep-fried in lard; among the highest sat-fat snacks in Filipino cuisine
Dinuguan (pork blood stew)	1 cup	H	L	H	AVOID	Pork blood + innards in pork fat broth; very high in cholesterol and sat fat
Laing (taro leaves in coconut cream)	1 cup	H	L	L	AVOID	Coconut cream = 15–25 g saturated fat per serving; reduce to minimal light gata
Bicol express (pork + gata + chili)	1 cup	H	L	M	AVOID	Double fat load: pork belly + thick coconut cream; use light gata + pork loin to modify
Kare-kare + bagoong (peanut oxtail stew)	1 bowl	H	M	M	AVOID	Peanut sauce + oxtail fat; bagoong adds very high sodium — also risky for CKD
Longganisa Vigan / sweet (cured fatty pork)	2 links 80g	H	M	M	AVOID	High sat fat + high sodium + sugar; nitrite preservatives compound cardiovascular risk
Paksiw na lechon / lechon sauce	1 cup	H	M	H	AVOID	Lechon fat recooked in liver-rich sauce; double cholesterol hit — liver is very high in CHOL
Adobo (pork belly, with skin)	1 cup	H	L	M	LIMIT	Use pork loin instead of belly; remove skin; drain fat before serving to reduce sat fat ~40%
Bulalo (bone marrow beef soup)	1 bowl	H	L	H	LIMIT	Bone marrow = very high cholesterol; eat lean meat only; discard fatty broth and marrow
Sinigang na baboy (pork)	1 bowl	M	L	M	LIMIT	Use lean pork (kasim); sinigang na isda is a far better swap with more omega-3
Menudo / Afritada / Caldereta (pork)	1 cup	M	M	M	LIMIT	Use lean pork; liver spread in caldereta adds dietary cholesterol — reduce amount or omit
Tocino (sweet-cured pork belly)	2 slices 80g	H	M	M	LIMIT	High sat fat + added sugar; prefer homemade lean pork versions; occasional treat only
Arroz caldo (pork or chicken rice porridge)	1 bowl	L	H	L	LIMIT	Low fat but high refined carbs (TG risk); use brown rice; top with tokwa instead of pork
Tinola (chicken + malunggay / sayote)	1 bowl	L	L	L	GOOD	Remove skin; eat chicken + vegetables; excellent everyday meal — best home-cooked option
Chicken adobo sa puti (no skin, no liver)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Lean chicken breast adobo; vinegar-based cooking preserves flavor without extra fat
Nilagang manok (boiled chicken)	1 bowl	L	L	L	GOOD	Excellent — remove skin; eat meat and vegetables; discard broth to reduce sodium
B · ISDA AT PAGKAIN SA DAGAT — FISH & SEAFOOD						
Crispy fried bangus (whole, with skin)	1 small	M	L	M	AVOID	Frying in coconut oil or lard adds large sat fat load; eat grilled or steamed instead
Sugpo / hipon (shrimp)	8 pcs medium	L	L	H	LIMIT	Low sat fat but high dietary cholesterol (~150mg/serving); limit to 1–2x/week
Pusit (squid, grilled or adobo)	1 cup	L	L	M	LIMIT	Moderate dietary cholesterol; avoid deep-fried tempura version
Talaba (oysters, raw or grilled)	6 pieces	L	L	M	LIMIT	Rich in zinc and omega-3; moderate cholesterol; avoid fried versions
Sinigang na bangus / tilapia / labahita	1 bowl	L	L	L	GOOD	Best Filipino soup — fish + vegetables + tamarind; limit broth intake for sodium
Inihaw na bangus (grilled milkfish, no skin)	1 medium	L	L	L	GOOD	Excellent omega-3 source; remove skin to cut sat fat further
Inihaw na galunggong (round scad, grilled)	2–3 pieces	L	L	L	GOOD	Best budget omega-3 fish in PH markets; grill or steam; avoid frying in coconut oil
Sardinas sa kamatis (canned, tomato sauce)	1 can	L	L	L	GOOD	Affordable EPA/DHA omega-3; choose tomato sauce or water — NOT oil-packed
Tilapia (steamed or grilled)	1 medium	L	L	L	GOOD	Lean white fish; mild omega-3; very affordable; cook without coconut oil
Tuyo (dried herring, grilled not fried)	2 pieces	L	L	L	GOOD	Good omega-3; very high sodium — limit to 1–2x/week; do NOT fry in extra oil
C · GULAY AT LEGUMES — VEGETABLES & LEGUMES · EAT FREELY						
Monggo guisado (mung bean stew)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Best soluble fiber staple; LDL-lowering; use canola oil, not lard, for sautéing
Pinakbet (no bagoong, canola oil)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Okra, ampalaya, eggplant — fiber-rich, LDL-lowering; skip the bagoong and lard
Ginisang kangkong (sautéed water spinach)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Use canola oil + garlic; add tokwa for protein; affordable heart-healthy staple
Ampalaya con huevo (bitter melon + egg)	1 cup	L	L	M	GOOD	Ampalaya lowers LDL and blood sugar; egg adds moderate dietary cholesterol — limit to 1 egg
Lumpiang sariwa (fresh spring rolls)	2 rolls	L	L	L	GOOD	Excellent — vegetables + tokwa wrapped in rice paper; avoid the fried lumpia version
Okra (steamed or in sinigang)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Highest soluble fiber vegetable in PH; viscous mucilage binds cholesterol in the gut

Food Item (Filipino Name / Brand)	Typical Serving	SF	SUG	CHOL	Rating	Key Note
E · KAKANIN AT MATAMIS — FILIPINO SWEETS & DESSERTS						
Leche flan	1 slice 100g	H	H	H	AVOID	Triple threat: egg yolks (cholesterol) + condensed milk (sat fat + sugar) — all three cells red
Biko / sinukmani (glutinous rice + gata)	1 piece	H	H	L	AVOID	Coconut cream + refined glutinous rice + sugar = high sat fat AND high TG together
Maja blanca (coconut milk pudding)	1 square	H	H	L	AVOID	Thick coconut cream + condensed milk + cornstarch; high sat fat and sugar
Polvoron (lard shortbread)	2 pieces	H	H	M	AVOID	Traditionally made with lard + condensed milk; check label for vegetable shortening versions
Ensaymada (butter + cream cheese topping)	1 large	H	M	M	AVOID	Butter filling + cream cheese topping = high sat fat; check for partially hydrogenated margarine
Halo-halo (full serving)	1 large glass	H	H	M	AVOID	Coconut cream + condensed milk + ube ice cream + multiple sugary toppings
Yema (egg yolk + condensed milk candy)	4 pieces	H	H	H	AVOID	Pure egg yolk + condensed milk = concentrated cholesterol and saturated fat in one candy
Bibingka (plain, no extra butter topping)	1 medium	M	M	M	LIMIT	Rice flour + egg + coconut milk; moderate in all; avoid extra butter topping
Champorado (chocolate rice porridge)	1 bowl	L	H	L	LIMIT	High refined carb + sugar → raises TG; skip condensed milk topping; use low-fat milk
Puto (plain, steamed rice cake)	3 pieces	L	M	L	LIMIT	Lower fat than most kakanin; refined rice starch raises TG if eaten in large amounts
Fresh papaya, melon, watermelon	1 cup cubed	L	L	L	GOOD	High fiber; natural sweetness without TG spike; best dessert choice after any meal
Boiled saba banana (no sugar)	2 pieces	L	L	L	GOOD	Resistant starch + fiber; healthy snack; do NOT fry or add sugar
F · FAST FOOD — JOLLIBEE · MANG INASAL · KFC · MCDONALD'S · CHOWKING						
Jollibee Chickenjoy (with skin + gravy)	1 piece	H	M	H	AVOID	Skin + batter = high sat fat; gravy adds sodium + starch thickeners + phosphate additives
KFC Original Recipe (with skin)	1 piece	H	L	H	AVOID	11-herb batter seals high sat fat in; skin contains most of the phosphate additives
Jolly Hotdog Classic (with cheese)	1 sandwich	H	M	M	AVOID	Hotdog = high sat fat + sodium phosphate; cheese adds more sat fat
Jollibee Jolly Spaghetti	1 regular	M	H	M	AVOID	Sweet banana ketchup sauce = high sugar → TG↑↑; hotdog slices add sat fat
McD McSpicy / McCrispy (with skin)	1 sandwich	H	M	H	AVOID	High sat fat from breading + palm oil frying; remove breading and skin to reduce impact
Burger King Whopper / McD Big Mac	1 burger	H	M	H	AVOID	Double beef patty + cheese + mayo = ~20g sat fat per burger; worst fast food choice
Chowking Lauriat (fried chicken + pork)	1 set	H	M	H	AVOID	Fried protein + sweet sauce + white rice combo = high sat fat + high TG
Mang Inasal Liempo (grilled pork belly)	1 slab	H	L	M	AVOID	Even grilled, pork belly fat remains; avoid the marinade-basted skin portions
Jollibee Chickenjoy (skin removed, no gravy)	1 piece	M	L	M	LIMIT	Removing skin cuts sat fat by ~40%; no gravy reduces sodium and thickeners significantly
Mang Inasal Paa (thigh, with skin)	1 piece	M	L	M	LIMIT	Grilled > fried; remove skin; use vinegar dip instead of chicken oil
McDo Filet-O-Fish	1 sandwich	M	M	M	LIMIT	Better than beef/chicken options; tartar sauce adds sat fat — ask for less sauce
Chowking Congee / Arroz caldo	1 bowl	L	H	L	LIMIT	Low fat but refined carb-heavy → TG↑; filling; avoid extra toppings
Mang Inasal Pecho (breast, no skin, vinegar dip)	1 piece	L	L	L	GOOD	Best fast food order in PH; grilled chicken breast + vinegar dip; skip chicken oil and unlimited rice
Chowking Tofu Sisig	1 serving	L	L	L	GOOD	Plant protein; low sat fat and cholesterol; watch sodium in sauce
McDo side corn / side salad (no dressing)	1 side	L	L	L	GOOD	Best side dish choices; request no dressing or use lemon wedge instead
G · GROCERY & PACKAGED FOODS — LATA · NAKA-PACK · SUPERMARKET						
Spam Original (Hormel)	2 slices 57g	H	L	M	AVOID	10g sat fat per serving + very high sodium; most popular processed meat in PH
Purefoods / CDO Hotdog (regular)	2 pieces	H	L	M	AVOID	High sat fat + sodium phosphate additives (100% absorbed); check label for "phosphate"
Argentina / CDO Corned Beef	½ can	H	L	M	AVOID	High sat fat + very high sodium; carrageenan filler in lower-grade brands
Ligo / CDO Vienna Sausage	1 can	H	L	M	AVOID	Processed pork + high sodium + phosphate preservatives; no nutritional benefit
Coconut cream / gata (Kara, Aroy-D)	½ cup	H	L	L	AVOID	~20g sat fat per ½ cup; most common hidden cholesterol-raiser in Filipino home cooking
Condensed milk (Alaska, Magnolia, Nestlé)	2 tbsp	M	H	M	AVOID	Very high sugar + sat fat; used in coffee, kakanin, and leche flan
Lucky Me Instant Pancit Canton / cup noodles	1 pack	M	H	L	AVOID	Palm-oil fried noodles + very high sodium + MSG; regular use raises TG and LDL

Food Item (Filipino Name / Brand)	Typical Serving	SF	SUG	CHOL	Rating	Key Note
H · COOKING OILS & FATS — MANTIKA AT TABA						
Coconut oil (VCO, Minola, Natura)	1 tbsp	H	L	L	AVOID	92% saturated fat — highest of any oil; consistent LDL-raiser in clinical trials
Lard / baboy fat (mantika ng baboy)	1 tbsp	H	L	L	AVOID	Still standard in many Filipino kitchens and carinderia; replace entirely with canola oil
Palm oil / palm shortening	1 tbsp	H	L	L	AVOID	50% sat fat; used in commercial frying, instant noodles, and many biscuit brands
Partially hydrogenated margarine (trans fat)	1 tbsp	H	L	L	AVOID	Raises LDL AND lowers HDL simultaneously — worst fat for the heart; check label for "hydrogenated"
Butter (Anchor, Gold Ribbon)	1 tbsp	H	L	L	LIMIT	7g sat fat per tbsp; use sparingly; replace with canola oil for cooking
Canola oil (Baguio Gold, Mazola)	1 tbsp	L	L	L	GOOD	Best for high-heat sautéing and frying; high MUFA, very low SFA; neutral taste
Extra virgin olive oil	1 tbsp	L	L	L	GOOD	Best for dressings and low-heat cooking; polyphenols add anti-inflammatory benefit
I · INUMIN — DRINKS & BEVERAGES						
Softdrinks (Coke, Sprite, Pepsi, Royal)	1 can 330mL	L	H	L	AVOID	35–40g sugar per can → TG↑↑; habitual intake is one of the fastest ways to raise triglycerides
Red Horse / San Miguel Beer	1 bottle 330mL	L	H	L	AVOID	Alcohol directly raises TG; stopping beer often drops TG 30–50% within weeks
Ginebra gin / Tanduay rum	1 shot + mixer	L	H	L	AVOID	Alcohol metabolism generates fat; spirits + juice/cola = compounded TG risk
3-in-1 coffee (Nescafe, Great Taste)	1 sachet	L	H	L	AVOID	Non-dairy creamer (palm oil) + sugar = high TG driver; switch to black brewed coffee
Sago't gulaman / buko pandan (sweetened)	1 large glass	L	H	L	AVOID	Arnibal (sugar syrup) + coconut cream = high sugar + sat fat; beloved but very high TG
Powdered juice drinks (Tang, 8 O'Clock, Zesto)	1 glass	L	H	L	AVOID	Almost pure sugar + artificial flavoring; no nutritional value; major TG raiser in Filipino diet
Milo / Ovaltine (hot or iced)	1 cup	L	M	L	LIMIT	Moderate sugar; use less powder than directed; prepare with skim or low-fat milk
Fresh buko (coconut) juice, no sugar added	1 coconut	L	M	L	LIMIT	Natural sugars; refreshing; acceptable if not diabetic; avoid bottled sweetened versions
Black coffee (barako, brewed, no sugar)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Paper-filtered is best; unfiltered (French press, boiled barako) may raise LDL slightly
Salabat (fresh ginger tea, no sugar)	1 cup	L	L	L	GOOD	Anti-inflammatory; traditional Filipino tea; small LDL-lowering effect; ideal post-meal drink
Unsweetened calamansi juice (fresh)	1 glass	L	L	L	GOOD	Vitamin C; very low sugar if no arnibal added; excellent with grilled fish
Plain water / mineral water	Any amount	L	L	L	GOOD	Best beverage; aim for 6–8 glasses/day; add calamansi slices for flavor

Lifestyle Changes That Move Your Lipid Panel

Aerobic Exercise ↑ HDL 3–9% · ↓ TG 10–20% 150 min/week brisk walking, swimming, or cycling. Shifts LDL particles to larger, less dangerous type.	⚖️ Weight Loss (5–10%) ↓ TG 20–30% · ↑ HDL 5–8% Even partial weight loss measurably improves all lipid values — every kilogram matters.	Reduce White Rice ↓ TG fast · ↓ TG/HDL ratio Liver converts excess refined carbs to VLDL fat. Smaller portions + brown rice.
Quit Smoking ↑ HDL within weeks Smoking lowers HDL 4–6 mg/dL. Quitting is the single most impactful cardiovascular intervention.	Stop Alcohol ↓ TG 30–50% in weeks If TG is elevated, stopping Red Horse and gin is often faster than any dietary change.	Sleep 7–8 Hours Modest lipid benefit Poor sleep raises LDL and TG independently. Stress raises cortisol → more VLDL secretion.

Sample Heart-Healthy Filipino Day	
Breakfast	Quaker oatmeal + sliced banana + 1 boiled egg (or tokwa scramble) + black barako coffee (never 3-in-1)
Lunch	½ cup brown rice + monggo guisado with malunggay + inihaw na galunggong + tomato-onion ensalada + unsweetened calamansi juice
Snack	30g pili nuts or cashews + fresh papaya or melon slices (eat the whole fruit — NOT juice)
Dinner	Sardines in tomato sauce (lata) + steamed kangkong with garlic in canola oil + small brown rice portion + salabat